NSUI, she was the face of a Congress ad which said, *'Kattar Soch Nahi, Yuva Josh'* (Not Fanaticism, but Youthfulness). A young Muslim leader from the Congress, Hasiba became the soft target for a slanderous campaign on social media, initiated by Internet Hindus. She was accused of being involved in a Rs 300 crore scam and having served a jail term. When I checked with my Goa correspondent, he said the reports were 'totally bogus'. I felt sorry for her—no one deserved to be abused in this manner—and rang her and expressed my sympathy. She thanked me in a tweet. The next thing I knew I was being accused of being a 'Congress agent'! In a highly charged election climate, this vitriol was not surprising.

The Hasiba episode, though, raises questions over the Congress ad strategy. Surely, if the party wanted to showcase its commitment to the youth, it didn't need a testimonial from one of its own. It should have gone out and got college students with no party affiliations to vouch for it. 'We shot sixty ads with party workers in different parts of the country because the party saw it as one way to enthuse its cadres,' says an ad executive involved in the campaign.

The Congress campaign was handled by Dentsu. The agency insists that phase one didn't go off too badly. 'We were getting good traction in January, but then the Rahul interview happened, and everything went downhill from there,' is how one of the agency executives described it to me. The leader had been shown up as a political novice on television—demoralization gradually set in.

Till January, the agency had been dealing mainly with Jairam Ramesh, Pradeep Kaul (a former adman and friend of the Gandhi family) and Suman Dubey (journalist and another friend of the Gandhis), with Priyanka Gandhi also, interestingly, being shown all the creatives. Suddenly, in February, a new face called Manoj Bhargava, an NRI entrepreneur from the US, landed up. Bhargava had reportedly run a successful energy drink business in the US and had impressed Rahul with a presentation on brand marketing. 'The guy started ordering us around and dropping Rahul Gandhi's name. He wanted a complete shift in the strategy,' I was told by a member of the ad team.